

FOUNDATIONS OF PHILIPPINE POPULAR CULTURE

Culture Overview

- **Definition:** Culture is the way you see the world, think, and express yourself in daily life, shaping everyday experiences.

Popular Culture

- **Definition:** Popular culture (or “pop culture”) refers to the everyday ideas, practices, and products embraced by the public. It reflects current trends and social values, evolving with the interests and experiences of ordinary people across different communities.

Characteristics of Popular Culture

- **Accessibility:** Easy to understand and available to people across ages and social classes.
 - *Local Example:* Barangay fiestas in urban and rural areas feature games, food, and contests that welcome people of all ages and backgrounds.
 - *Global Example:* Outdoor movie nights (open-air cinemas or drive-in theaters) held worldwide feature popular films for free or at low cost.
- **Popularity:** Becomes mainstream because many people relate to or participate in it.
 - *Local Example:* Jeepney culture is part of Filipino pop culture as a symbol of everyday life shown through colorful designs, local artwork, music, and media presence.
 - *Global Example:* Street basketball popularized worldwide through movies, music videos, and urban fashion.
- **Commercialism:** Elements created and marketed for profit, such as fan merchandise, events, and digital content.
 - *Local Example:* TOYCON PH, the Philippines’ largest and longest-running convention for toys, hobbies, and collectibles, draws around 50,000 visitors annually and generates income through sales of action figures, fan-made art, and pop culture merchandise.
 - *Global Example:* Funko Pop! figures and LEGO sets featuring famous movie and TV characters widely bought, collected, and traded.
- **Summary Distinction:** Accessibility focuses on how easily people from all backgrounds experience pop culture; popularity centers on widespread appeal and shared participation; commercialism highlights profit driven by marketing and consumer products.

High Culture

- **Definition:** Artistic and intellectual expressions associated with educated and elite sectors of society, valued for historical, aesthetic, and intellectual depth.

Characteristics of High Culture

- **Validation:** Supported and legitimized by formal institutions such as museums, orchestras, universities, and cultural centers that preserve, fund, and promote art forms.
 - *Local Example:* The National Museum of the Philippines preserves and displays cultural heritage through a nationwide network of museums.
 - *Global Example:* The Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York promotes high culture through its collection and educational programs.
- **Sophistication:** Emphasizes creativity, intellectual depth, and refined techniques, often studied in academic settings and praised by critics.
 - *Local Example:* The Philippine Philharmonic Orchestra is acclaimed for skilled performances and featured in cultural and academic events.
 - *Global Example:* The compositions of Johann Sebastian Bach are studied in music conservatories and performed by symphony orchestras worldwide.
- **Exclusivity:** Access can be limited by cost, location, or social perception, often making it more accessible to privileged groups.
 - *Local Example:* Performances at the Cultural Center of the Philippines, such as operas or symphonies, can be expensive and primarily attract affluent audiences.
 - *Global Example:* Attending performances at prestigious venues like the Vienna State Opera is often costly and requires familiarity with classical music.
- **Summary Distinction:** Validation focuses on institutional support; sophistication highlights quality and depth; exclusivity points to limited access reserved for the privileged.

Folk Culture

- **Definition:** Customs and practices that grow within communities and are shared through daily interaction and participation. It is not made for profit or mass appeal, but takes everyday forms like songs, dances, crafts, and stories passed on through personal and communal experience.

Characteristics of Folk Culture

- **Tradition:** Rooted in customs and knowledge passed down through generations by word of mouth or daily practice to maintain cultural continuity over time.
 - *Local Example:* The Hudhud chants of the Ifugao are an oral tradition performed during agricultural and communal rituals to preserve ancestral knowledge, values, and history.
 - *Global Example:* European folk tales, such as *Little Red Riding Hood* or *Jack and the Beanstalk*, originated in oral storytelling traditions to entertain, impart lessons, and strengthen cultural identity.
- **Locality:** Shaped by distinct practices, materials, and ways of life tied to a specific region, environment, or community.
 - *Local Example:* In the Cordillera Administrative Region, traditional Kalinga tattooing (*Batok*) reflects tribal identity, records milestones, and represents community status.

- *Global Example:* In New Zealand, the Māori practice of *tā moko* is a traditional form of tattooing art that varies by tribe/region and symbolizes identity, ancestry, and belonging.
- **Symbolism:** Everyday rituals and objects express deeper beliefs, spiritual values, or social meanings central to the community.
 - *Local Example:* In Sagada, the tradition of *Panag-apoy* involves families lighting bonfires in cemeteries on All Saints' Day to honor and connect with ancestors.
 - *Global Example:* In Japan, *Obon* is an annual Buddhist tradition honoring ancestor spirits through lantern lighting and ancestral offerings.
- **Summary Distinction:** Tradition focuses on time and continuity; locality emphasizes place and setting; symbolism highlights meaning and purpose.

The Role of Cultural Institutions

- **Overview:** Key institutions promote high culture and folk culture in the Philippines.

NCCA (National Commission for Culture and the Arts)

- **Enactment:** Enacted through Republic Act No. 7356 on April 3, 1992, as the national government agency for culture and the arts.
- **Function:** Serves as the country's overall policymaking, coordinating, and grants-giving body.
- **Scope:** Supports indigenous traditions, folk practices, contemporary works, and high art.
- **Awards Administered:** Administers national awards like *Gawad sa Manlilikha ng Bayan* (GAMABA) for National Living Treasures and co-administers the Order of National Artists (*Orden ng mga Pambansang Alagad ng Sining*) with the CCP.

CCP (Cultural Center of the Philippines)

- **Establishment:** Established in 1966 to promote and present performing and visual arts.
- **Focus:** Focuses primarily on high culture (classical music, ballet, theater, visual arts), but features folk and contemporary works via festivals and outreach programs.
- **Initiatives:** Hosts major cultural events and educational initiatives across artistic disciplines.

Collaborative Showcase Example:

- **Philippine Pavilion at Expo 2025 Osaka:** Opened April 13, 2025, themed "*Nature, Culture, and Community: Woven Together for a Better Future.*"
- **Details:** Highlights cultural heritage through the largest collaboration of Filipino weavers. Supported by the NCCA and coordinated by the Department of Tourism (DOT) and Tourism Promotions Board (TPB). Features a woven-inspired design by Carlo Calma Consultancy Inc., with creative production by Chochay Garcia, architect Yuki Kanou, Tellart, and Ballet Philippines, blending traditional craftsmanship with technology.

Indigenous Peoples in the Philippines

- **Background:** Have historical ties to pre-colonial societies and practice traditional beliefs, oral storytelling, farming, and self-governance.
- **Terminology:**
 - *Indigenous Peoples (IPs)*: Broad legal term recognizing the collective rights of native ethnic groups.
 - *Indigenous Cultural Communities (ICCs)*: Refers to specific local communities sharing common cultural practices and traditions.

Indigenous Cultural Communities (ICCs) by Region

- **Luzon:** Igorot of the Cordilleras, Aeta, Mangyan, and Palawan peoples (known for deep ties to ancestral land and traditional practices).
- **Visayas:** Ati of Panay Island (maintain unique identities despite smaller populations).
- **Mindanao:** Lumad (collective term for non-Muslim Indigenous groups) and Moro (Indigenous Muslim communities with rich cultural/historical traditions).

Legal Rights and Support Systems

- **IPRA Law:** Indigenous Peoples' Rights Act of 1997 (Republic Act No. 8371) upholds rights to ancestral land, self-governance, and cultural integrity despite marginalization and displacement challenges.
- **Implementing Bodies & Programs:**
 - *NCIP*: National Commission on Indigenous Peoples implements IPRA.
 - *IPED*: DepEd Indigenous Peoples Education Program promotes culture-based learning.
 - *IPMR*: Indigenous Peoples Mandatory Representative ensures Indigenous voices in local governance.

Indigenous Influence on Folk Culture

- ICCs are central to Philippine folk culture roots through oral traditions, rituals, weaving, music, and nature-based practices, preserving heritage and localized, sustainable ways of life.

Practicing Cultural Sensitivity

- **Definition:** Engaging with Indigenous cultures respectfully and responsibly to prevent harmful stereotypes and misuse of traditions (e.g., sacred attire as fashion).
- **Key Actions:**
 1. *Engage*: Build knowledge from reliable sources and listen to Indigenous voices (e.g., attend events or read works by Lumad authors/scholars).
 2. *Consult*: Ask permission before using designs, symbols, or stories (e.g., consult T'boli artisans before using T'boli patterns).
 3. *Support*: Give proper credit to creators and promote work fairly (e.g., name Aeta artisans when sharing crafts and promote ethical support).

Cultural Studies Theory

- **Definition:** Interdisciplinary field exploring how culture connects with power, identity, and society through media, language, and beliefs. Integrates sociology, literature, Marxism, and feminism.

Core Principles of Cultural Studies Theory

1. **Power:** Culture is a non-neutral space where power is expressed, challenged, and negotiated to maintain authority or resist dominant norms.
 - *Example:* Young people creating street art criticizing the government to push back against political power.
2. **Representation:** Portrayals of people, groups, and issues in media shape societal understanding and can reinforce harmful stereotypes.
 - *Example:* News outlets focusing exclusively on negative stories about a region or culture, fostering fear.
3. **Interpretation:** Audiences actively create meaning from cultural messages based on personal experiences, beliefs, and backgrounds.
 - *Example:* The *pagmamano* tradition being viewed as respectful by older generations, but seen as outdated by some younger Filipinos.

Key Theorists and Cultural Contributions

- **Stuart Hall (1932–2014):** Developed the encoding/decoding model showing audiences actively interpret media messages based on social context. Focused on hegemony, race, identity, and negotiated meaning.
- **Raymond Williams (1921–1988):** Asserted that "culture is ordinary," validating everyday life and popular practices. Introduced "structures of feeling" (unspoken emotional/cultural experiences shaped by history) and a materialist approach linking cultural forms to social/economic foundations.
- **Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937):** Formulated the theory of cultural hegemony (dominant groups maintain power by shaping cultural norms). Introduced the concept of organic intellectuals emerging from marginalized communities to challenge dominant ideologies.

Applications of Cultural Studies Theory

- **Media and Communication:** Analyzes how communication practices and media influence daily meaning-making and representation.
 - *Example:* Beauty commercials presenting fair skin as essential for beauty and success.
- **Subcultures and Youth Culture:** Examines how marginalized subcultures (punk, hip-hop, skateboarding) create identities resisting mainstream norms.
 - *Example:* Filipino teens using rap music to address societal problems.
- **Postcolonial Studies:** Explores how colonialism shapes identity, language, cultural hybridity, and power in formerly colonized societies.
 - *Example:* Filipinos using English over native languages in school or formal settings.
- **Gender and Queer Studies:** Uses feminist and queer theory to examine representation of gender roles and identities in institutions and media.

- *Example:* Teleseryes depicting women primarily as housewives rather than leaders.